

FRACTURED TRUST
A stewardess attending to passengers on an Air India flight, April 2024

CHALLENGE 4
THE PILOT CRISIS

Staffing remains one of Air India's key challenges as it seeks to scale operations. As of early 2025, the airline had around 3,280 active pilots—a mix of seasoned veterans and new recruits—but that pool remains insufficient for its rapid expansion. The shortage has forced the airline to increasingly rely on expatriate pilots: by 2024, 58 foreign pilots were flying leased Boeing 777s due to a lack of type-rated Indian captains. (Type rating refers to certification aviation authorities grant to pilots who have completed training and testing on a specific type of aircraft.) This marks a shift from Air India's historically Indian pilot corps and underscores a transitional dependency rather than a permanently thin talent pipeline. But rival IndiGo operates with a much larger base of 5,463 pilots, almost all of them Indian.

Tensions within the cockpit, too, are rising. The integration of Vistara's pilots into Air India's ranks in 2023–24 has been anything but smooth. In March 2024, Vistara pilots staged a mass sick leave protest over revised pay structures that reportedly slashed salaries for junior pilots by as much as 50 per cent. Such unrest, even if sporadic, points to deeper dissatisfaction over compensation and contract terms.

The Ahmedabad crash has further heightened scrutiny of crew preparedness and safety practices. In its June 20 notice, the DGCA highlighted "systemic failures in scheduling protocol and oversights" that led to two Air India flights from Bengaluru to London exceeding the maximum allowable duty hours on consecutive days in May. Add to that the growing anxiety among crew members in the aftermath of the crash, and concerns are mounting over fatigue, morale, and whether the airline is stretching its resources too thin.

To its credit, Air India has ramped up recruitment and training. Since its privatisation, more than 1,500 cadet and type-rated pilots have been added across its A320, A350 and 737 fleet. But with at least 470 aircraft on order, Air India will need an estimated 5,000–6,000 pilots over the next decade, according to aviation consultancy CAPA India and DGCA projections. The government, too, has acknowledged the need for a larger, future-ready pilot workforce to keep pace with India's aviation boom.

CHALLENGE 5
POOR PUNCTUALITY

The story of Air India's dismal on-time performance (OTP) was an open secret in the days before the Tatas stepped in. In October 2019, its rate of on-time departures was just 54.3 per cent. By October 2022, soon after the takeover, it clocked an impressive 90.8 per cent OTP, a dramatic turnaround that took it well ahead of other Indian airlines. Yet, it has been difficult to maintain this tempo. In December 2024, its OTP on domestic routes dropped to 67.6 per cent, about six percentage points below IndiGo's 73.4 per cent. While airline delays rose across the board in 2024 due to extrinsic rollbacks, Air India still has a lot of ground to cover. Its average OTP, though better than the dismal 50–60 per cent seen pre-2022, remains stuck in the 60–80 per cent range—a clear sign that reliability isn't yet a given.

The airline, however, cited a Cirium Aviation Analytics report to point out that it ranked among Asia's top 10 most punctual carriers for the first time in March 2025. "Over 80 per cent of Air India flights arrived within 15 minutes of schedule, with a flight completion rate of 99.8 per cent," the spokesperson told INDIA TODAY.



"It is time India had institutional accountability for air safety, for which a strong regulator is key. It is not just about the airlines, but the entire system"

— KAPIL KAUL, *CEO, CAPA India*